

Five-Question Math Understanding Check

Use a familiar math problem. Ask calmly, give thinking time, and record your child's explanation before offering help.

Child: _____ Topic / date: _____

Problem your child solved:

1. Why does that work? Ask for the reason behind a step, not just the name of a rule.

Explained independently / Explained with prompts / Needs more exploration

2. Can you teach it to me? Have them explain the idea as if you have never learned it. A drawing or objects are welcome.

Explained independently / Explained with prompts / Needs more exploration

3. What if the problem changes? Change the numbers, wording, or representation. Can they connect it to the same idea?

Explained independently / Explained with prompts / Needs more exploration

4. What does the answer mean? Ask what the result represents and how they can tell it makes sense.

Explained independently / Explained with prompts / Needs more exploration

5. What could you try if you got stuck? Listen for a plan: draw it, try a simpler case, estimate, or check a step.

Explained independently / Explained with prompts / Needs more exploration

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Turn observations into a next step. One hesitant explanation is a reason to explore together, not to label a child.

Example: adding fractions

Start with $\frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{4}$. Ask your child to draw the fractions on equal-sized wholes, explain why the pieces need a common size, and show why the answer is $\frac{3}{4}$.

Then vary the problem: $\frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{6}$. Can they explain why the same idea works? If they are stuck, offer a drawing and notice what support makes the idea clearer.

Look across the five responses

What you observed	A useful next step
Explains why and adapts to a new example.	Try a slightly richer problem and ask for a second approach.
Gets the answer but only repeats a rule.	Use a diagram, objects, or a simpler case to connect the rule to meaning.
Understands after a prompt or drawing.	Practice another example, then revisit it later with less support.
The same idea is unclear across several examples.	Save the examples and discuss the pattern with a teacher or tutor.

The idea that needs more exploration:

Activity to try / date to revisit / what changed:

Bring this page and a sample of your child's work to a conversation with the learning team: ritetutor.com/contact.